



DEV PATEL (LEFT)
WITH ANIL KAPOOR
IN A STILL FROM
THE MOVIE

“Instead of India crossing over to the West, the West has come to India.”

VIJAY SINGH
CEO, FOX STAR STUDIOS

been downbeat, ending in blood (*Revolutionary Road*), bullets (*Gran Torino*), ignominy (*Frost/Nixon*) and in the case of *The Wrestler*, a leap into certain death. “It’s a \$15-million movie made with almost no stars and a great script. It’s an eye-opener for Bollywood,” says Vijay Singh, CEO of Fox Star Studios, which is releasing over 200 prints of the film in Hindi and English in India.

It was possible, as co-director Loveleen Tandan puts it, only because of Boyle’s amazing energy. Ok, this is no *Gandhi*, where Richard Attenborough spent 20 years making a movie based on India’s most famous man. But it may well do for India what *Gandhi* couldn’t, attracting A-list talent from abroad to make Indian movies. It’s something Kapoor will be looking forward to. The actor, who underwent a seven-day

workshop with Siddhartha Basu at *Kaun Banega Crorepati*’s set, is amazed at the professionalism. “Whenever they were shooting at Victoria Terminus, Danny, I and Dev Patel, who plays the oldest Jamal, would rehearse in the hotel room. Not like here, where dialogues are given when the camera is rolling,” he says.

It’s a collaborative triumph with casting director Tandan playing a vital role, writing the Hindi dialogue for the children and directing them as well. “But it was extraordinarily generous of Danny to give me co-director credit,” she says. Tandan, like everyone else associated with the movie, started believing in the film’s destiny only after it was unveiled at the Telluride Film Festival where *The Wall Street Journal*’s Joe Morgenstern gave it a thumbs-up. Since then, the movie

has made \$31 million at the box-office and the rave reviews haven’t stopped coming. The camerawork by Anthony Dod Mantle who shot *The Last King of Scotland* is dazzling, partly the result of using the smaller SI-2K silicon imaging camera to shoot unobtrusively in the slums. Simon Beaufoy’s screenplay is deft, borrowing all the elements of a Salim-Javed potboiler from Vikas Swarup’s *Q & A*, and altering some—changing the lead character’s religion, inventing Latika and making Salim the brother instead of the friend. The direction is heartfelt, and yet nuanced. Instead of Boyle being the nervous outsider, it’s as if he is Jamal Malik sitting in the hotseat in a scene from the movie, and asking the seasoned host Prem Kumar, “Are you nervous?”

He needn’t have been. As Jamal would say, it is written. ■